

V5 Building Vulnerability Norms

Pillar	Vulnerability	Difficulty	Level 2
Time Required	45-55 minutes	Group Size	5-15
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	V1 (Vulnerability Circle) completed	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Team wants to sustain vulnerability gains from V1/V2, building agreed team norms, transition from one-off exercise to ongoing practice

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

One vulnerability exercise creates a temporary oxytocin spike. For lasting change, the brain needs repeated, consistent signals that vulnerability is safe in this environment. That consistency comes from explicit norms, agreed behaviours that the team commits to and can hold each other accountable for.

Explicit norms work because they reduce ambiguity. The brain spends enormous energy scanning for social rules ("Is it safe to say this? Will I be punished for admitting that?"). When the rules are stated clearly, cognitive load drops and the prefrontal cortex can focus on the actual work instead of social risk assessment.

Teams that create their own norms (rather than having them imposed) show stronger adherence because ownership activates intrinsic motivation circuitry (dopamine). Being told to be vulnerable produces compliance. Choosing to be vulnerable produces commitment.

Before You Begin

This exercise works best when the team has already experienced V1 (Vulnerability Circle) or V2 (Failure Stories). It builds on those experiences to create lasting structures. Without the experiential foundation, the norms will be abstract rather than grounded.

The Exercise

Phase 1: Anchoring in Experience (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Think back to the vulnerability exercise we did recently. What made it work? What made it feel safe enough to be honest? And, if there were moments where it felt less safe, what caused that?"

"Write down two things: one thing that made it feel safe, and one thing that would have made it feel safer."

Collect responses on flipchart/Miro. Group into themes. Common themes: confidentiality, not being judged, manager going first, having time to think before speaking, knowing it was okay to pass.

Phase 2: From Experiences to Norms (15 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"These are the conditions that made vulnerability work for us. Now I want to turn them into agreements. Not rules imposed from above. Agreements we make with each other about how we'll operate going forward."

"For each theme on the board, can we turn it into a specific, observable behaviour? Not 'be respectful' (too vague). Something like 'when someone shares a struggle, we listen without immediately offering solutions.'"

Guide the team to create 4-6 norms. More than six is too many to remember. Each norm should be:

- Specific enough to observe ("we don't interrupt during shares" not "we listen")
- Phrased as a commitment, not a prohibition ("we ask before giving advice" not "don't give unsolicited advice")
- Something the team can hold each other to ("any of us can call a timeout if this norm is being broken")

Phase 3: Stress-Testing the Norms (10 minutes)

This is the step most facilitation guides skip. Norms that are not stress-tested will fail under pressure.

WHAT TO SAY

"Now let's pressure-test these. Think about the hardest conversation we might have as a team in the next month. A project going wrong. A disagreement about priorities. A resource being cut. Would these norms hold up? Is there anything missing?"

Adjust the norms based on what surfaces. If the team identifies a scenario where the norms would break, add or modify a norm to address it.

Phase 4: Accountability Design (5 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Last question. How do we hold each other to these? Not how do I hold you to them. How do we, collectively, make sure these stay alive? What happens when someone breaks a norm? And what happens when someone lives one particularly well?"

Common answers: anyone can name a norm break in the moment (using agreed language like "I think we're breaking norm 3"); norms get reviewed in a monthly team retrospective; the manager checks in on norms during 1:1s.

Phase 5: Close and Commit (5 minutes)

Write the final norms on a single page. Each person signs or verbally commits. Post them visibly (office wall, Teams channel header, Miro board that stays open). Norms that are hidden are norms that are forgotten.

WHAT TO SAY

"These are our agreements. Not aspirations. Agreements. I'll bring them back in four weeks and we'll check: which ones are we living? Which ones need adjusting? The norms are not permanent. They evolve as we do."

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
The team creates norms that are too vague ("Be supportive")	Push for specificity: "What does 'supportive' look like in practice? Give me an example." If they say "listening without judging," ask "what does that look like in a meeting when someone says something you disagree with?" Keep pushing until the norm is observable.
One person dominates the norm-setting process	Use written input first: everyone writes their norm suggestions on sticky notes before discussing. This ensures all voices contribute before the dominant voice shapes the conversation.
The team treats this as a one-time exercise rather than a living agreement	Schedule the review into the calendar before ending the session. Put it in writing. If the review doesn't happen, the norms decay within 6 weeks.

Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
During the session	The team debates the norms genuinely (not rubber-stamping) Someone raises a norm that challenges the manager's behaviour (a sign of real psychological safety) The stress-test phase produces genuine scenarios, not safe hypotheticals
Within 2-4 weeks	A team member references a norm during a real conversation ("We agreed to ask before giving advice") The norms are visibly posted and people notice A norm break is named without defensiveness or conflict
CLOVER ERA data (4-6 weeks)	Vulnerability and communication scores sustain or increase (not just spike and drop)

	Qualitative data references team agreements, safety, or openness
Red flags	If the norms exist on paper but are never referenced, the exercise produced compliance not commitment. Revisit V1 to rebuild the experiential foundation.

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
V1: Vulnerability Circle	V5 codifies the trust that V1 creates. Without V1, the norms are theoretical.	Run V1 first (2-4 weeks before V5)
V2: Failure Stories	V2 gives the team a shared experience of vulnerability that V5 can reference when building norms.	Run V2 before V5 if possible
R14: Linking Reflections to Outcomes	Norm review sessions are a form of structured reflection. R14 provides the framework for making those reviews produce action.	Complementary
C9: Conflict Communication	Vulnerability norms directly support healthier conflict. The norms should reference how the team handles disagreement.	Run V5 before C9